

Chapter 127-1

The hospital room was spotlessly clean. Liang Shi's body was still very heavy—she could hear her bones cracking when she turned her neck.

Her manager Wang Zhaozhao's face suddenly appeared before her eyes. Everything was like a scroll being unfurled, the entire world vividly and actively presenting itself before Liang Shi.

Meanwhile, the memories that had seemed so vivid in the thick fog just moments ago instantly dimmed in her mind.

Liang Shi only called out "Wang-jie" in a hoarse voice, and Wang Zhaozhao's tears fell. She couldn't be bothered to maintain her usual elegance and instinctively raised the back of her hand to wipe them away, though her expression remained stern.

Liang Shi stiffly managed a smile and pretended to be relaxed: "What are you crying for?"

Wang Zhaozhao glared at her, her tone reproachful: "I've never seen anyone as unlucky as you."

Every word Liang Shi spoke, she could feel her vocal cords vibrating, and even her brain was aching along with it—just like the glitching static sounds from the system that had been ringing in her mind before.

Yet she still forced herself to comfort Wang-jie: "Don't cry, I'm fine."

Wang-jie instinctively wanted to reach out and swat her. Her hand was already extended, but seemingly considering that she had just woken up, her hand hung in the air and swatted at nothing, then awkwardly retracted. She scolded: "Not dying is good enough."

Liang Shi didn't respond to her words. Her mind was like a slideshow playing, with frame after frame of images appearing—all unfamiliar scenes.

A city with towering buildings, vehicles shuttling back and forth on the Yujiang Bridge, crowds along the coastline in the outskirts of Haizhou City.

...

Those scenes kept entering Liang Shi's mind, bombarding her brain.

Liang Shi's pupils had already become unfocused.

Assistant Xiao Bai moved quickly on her end, swiftly calling for a doctor.

But the moment the doctor entered the hospital room, Liang Shi's head was like a machine that couldn't handle the heavy load. Her eyelids grew heavy, and she passed out again.

"Liang Shi!"

"Liang-jie!"

Overlapping worried voices rang in her ears. The last thought Liang Shi had as her consciousness faded was: If she remained unconscious like this, could she return to Xu Qingzhu's side?

Chapter 127-2

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Zhao Xuning taking Xu Qingzhu to see the unconscious Liang Shi was a very bold decision.

Dr. Gu had also considered this approach before, but was afraid that Xu Qingzhu would be impacted again, causing her psychological defenses to crumble once more.

But Zhao Xuning's reason for persuading her was simple: they had to try—things couldn't possibly get worse than they already were.

Dr. Gu agreed, but also made thorough preparations. Her white coat pockets contained both sedatives and suppressants.

Xu Qingzhu's heat period would arrive soon.

Generally, an Omega's heat period lasts 3-7 days. After taking suppressants, they can carry out normal social activities, but need to stay away from Alpha pheromone interference.

Last time, Xu Qingzhu's heat period was forcibly brought forward and lasted only a short time—it ended in just one day.

If this heat period arrived, it would likely make up for the shortened days from last time, and the symptoms would be more intense than any previous time, requiring more powerful suppressants to withstand.

With such preparations in place, Zhao Xuning then took Xu Qingzhu to Liang Shi's hospital room.

Their rooms were only a few dozen meters apart.

Liang Shi's hospital room was empty. The nurse had just changed her dressings, and the wounds on her body were slowly recovering.

Logically speaking, a young Alpha like Liang Shi with good physical constitution would have a significant advantage in wound recovery.

If Liang Shi were awake, eating nutritious meals on time every day with occasional supplementation, the wounds on her body would need only about ten days to mostly recover. But now she was unconscious every day, her blood circulation was slow, and it would take a month to recover.

Currently, the experts in the hospital still couldn't determine the reason for Liang Shi's continued unconsciousness.

The surgery that day had gone relatively smoothly and hadn't injured any vital areas. A CT scan of the brain had been done—no blood clots compressing nerves.

Yet Liang Shi had developed these symptoms.

Fortunately, her body showed no abnormalities. All they could do was wait.

Xu Qingzhu followed Zhao Xuning into Liang Shi's hospital room, expressionless the entire way.

Her face still had no color. She hadn't eaten much since waking up. When she stood and walked, her figure seemed to float. Walking through the hospital corridor in fuzzy slippers, her footsteps couldn't be heard at all.

Like a soulless wandering ghost¹.

So frail that a gust of wind could blow her away.

Zhao Xuning pushed open the door, and the scene inside the hospital room unfolded before Xu Qingzhu's eyes—a spotlessly clean room, Liang Shi lying quietly on the bed, her long brown curly hair spread across the pillow.

Although Liang Shi was the one who had lost too much blood, her face already had some color—much better than Xu Qingzhu's.

Her lips were a bit chapped, her breathing was even, and her long eyelashes cast a layer of shadow on her lower eyelids.

It was afternoon, and the early winter sunlight fell gently on her, like a beautiful painting with vivid colors.

It looked incredibly healing.

Xu Qingzhu stood at the doorway, not moving for a long time, her expression unchanged.

Zhao Xuning had already entered the room. She took out gloves and put them on, then put on a mask, and moved aside the clothing at Liang Shi's collarbone to check her wounds. The recovery was good—there was no deterioration.

There were benefits to recovering while unconscious—she wouldn't move around randomly.

Liang Shi lay there as if she were just asleep.

After Zhao Xuning finished her examination, she looked at Xu Qingzhu standing at the doorway. Her face hidden behind the mask was cold, but her voice carried a touch of warmth: "Won't you come in and take a look?"

Xu Qingzhu was dazed for a moment, then walked in extremely carefully.

Each step she took was very light, as if afraid of disturbing the person lying on the hospital bed.

Zhao Xuning stepped back half a pace, hands in her coat pockets, her voice muffled: "You can talk to her."

Xu Qingzhu's reaction was muted. Her long, curled eyelashes fluttered lightly a few times, like a butterfly flapping its wings. She sat down on the chair by the hospital bed on her own, lowering her eyes to look at Liang Shi.

She remained calm throughout.

But a few seconds after sitting down, her tears fell pattering onto the back of Liang Shi's hand.

The IV drip on the back of Liang Shi's hand had just finished, and the nurse had forgotten to tuck her hand under the blanket. So all those glistening teardrops fell onto it, landing on those prominent veins.

Zhao Xuning and Gu Junru exchanged a glance from across the room.

Neither of them moved.

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1. "Wandering ghost" (阿飄) - A colloquial Taiwanese/Chinese term for ghosts or spirits. The term literally suggests something that floats or drifts, emphasizing the ethereal, weightless nature of ghosts. Here it's used to describe how weak and insubstantial Xu Qingzhu appeared. ⇐

Chapter 127-3

Xu Qingzhu opened her mouth wanting to speak, but stopped.

After several attempts, she finally spoke her first sentence: "How long has she been unconscious?"

Her cool, clear voice was choked with emotion.

Zhao Xuning answered coldly: "Three days. A full body examination has been done—there are no obvious abnormalities."

"Then will she still come back?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Zhao Xuning's pupils contracted slightly, startled by her words. Then she said with certainty: "She will."

But after saying it, she felt a bit uncertain—she wasn't sure either.

This was Liang Shi's secret, known only to the two of them.

Zhao Xuning didn't know why Xu Qingzhu immediately asked if Liang Shi would "come back" rather than "wake up."

At the time, Zhao Xuning hadn't thought of this issue either. She was inclined to explain everything through medicine, so she had stayed up all night with the department head researching the reason for Liang Shi's continued unconsciousness.

She had even made overseas calls to authorities in this field, but received no answers.

It was only when medicine couldn't explain it that Zhao Xuning thought of those things Liang Shi had mentioned before—though she hadn't fully believed them.

But unexpectedly, Xu Qingzhu had immediately asked this question.

Zhao Xuning couldn't discuss it with her right now.

After asking this question, Xu Qingzhu also fell quiet.

She seemed to only be searching for a point—a point that could help her stand up and support herself.

After a long silence, she suddenly asked coldly: "What about Chen Liuying?"

Zhao Xuning: "Hm?"

"Dr. Gu." Xu Qingzhu raised her head to look at Gu Junru. She licked her lips. "I... let's talk."

Gu Junru was pleasantly surprised: "Alright."

After saying this, Xu Qingzhu slowly bent down.

It was a very slow movement—if placed in a film, it would definitely be a scene beautiful enough to replay multiple times.

Xu Qingzhu closed her eyes, her eyelashes trembling. She brushed the hair by her ear aside, slowly bent down, and her moist lips landed on the back of Liang Shi's hand as tears fell simultaneously.

Liang Shi's fingers instinctively curled, then remained completely still.

After Xu Qingzhu straightened up, her fingers gently brushed across the back of Liang Shi's hand, wiping away the tears on it.

She gritted her teeth, looking at that quiet face on the hospital bed.

The hospital room was so silent that only the slowed breathing could be heard. Xu Qingzhu's fingertips landed on Liang Shi's jaw, tracing lightly across it in a caressing manner.

Tears welled up in Xu Qingzhu's eyes. She opened her mouth several times but couldn't get a single word out.

After a long while, she said in a choked voice: "Jiejie."

The person on the hospital bed didn't respond.

Seeing that she had recovered somewhat, Zhao Xuning beckoned Dr. Gu to wait outside.

The door was closed, sealing off a gentle universe.

In this universe, there were only the two of them.

"This time." Xu Qingzhu's head gently rested beside her, avoiding the area with her hand.

Their heartbeats mingled together. Xu Qingzhu's voice was soft and tender: "It's my turn to protect you."

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When Liang Shi woke up again, it was evening. The bright and clean hospital room was very quiet.

When she opened her eyes, she saw the white ceiling and the pungent smell of disinfectant.

Having smelled it for so long, she didn't find it too irritating anymore.

She stiffly turned her head. In the distant sky were orange-pink clouds, continuously spreading out. The remaining glow of the setting sun scattered across the city buildings with their towering high-rises—beautiful like an oil painting.

There was no one in the hospital room. After two episodes of unconsciousness, her mind was finally somewhat clear.

The scene before her was so beautiful it seemed to have stepped out of a painting. She had no way of determining where this place was.

The Wang-jie she had seen before seemed like a dream, but reason told her this seemed to be the place where she had lived for many years.

Her throat was dry and hoarse, unable to speak. Her body was also ridiculously stiff—any slight movement made her feel pain all over, as if pulling one hair would affect her whole body.

Liang Shi exerted great effort just to raise her hand, wanting to press the bell on the side of the hospital bed. But just as she raised her hand, the hospital room door was pushed open and familiar voices rang out.

"Can Liang-jie even wake up? I got excited for nothing."

"She can wake up. Just wait a bit longer."

Two voices came through. A moment later, both people exclaimed in surprise simultaneously: "You're awake?!"

Xiao Bai ran out like she had gone crazy, sprinting at the speed of a hundred-meter dash to find Liang Shi's attending physician. Wang Zhaozhao stood there ramrod straight, and after a moment, adjusted the non-prescription glasses she wore as decoration.

Liang Shi and she looked at each other, as if across a century.

Liang Shi closed her eyes briefly, and a tear rolled down.

Her heart was filled with mixed emotions, yet she still managed a stiff smile.

Liang Shi's voice was hoarse and raspy, sounding as if it were being ground by a blunt object as she spoke.

She said: "Wang-jie, I'm back."

—Long time no see.

Wang Zhaozhao let out a soft breath. "Thank goodness."

—Thank goodness you woke up.

Chapter 127-4

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The doctor came to give Liang Shi a comprehensive physical examination, confirming that her body had no major issues.

It's just that a normal person lying in bed for over three months would inevitably have some problems.

The problem Liang Shi faced was body stiffness—she needed rehabilitation.

Rehabilitation was quite a difficult process. Especially after Liang Shi came back and discovered she had been lying in bed for over three months—even her abs had disappeared from lying down. Her body was too thin, like a paper cutout.

Liang Shi would do rehabilitation for about two hours every day. Because her physical foundation was good, she didn't need to do too many exercises, but Liang Shi would add extra training for herself.

The doctor's recommendation was about two hours, so Xiao Bai would supervise her walking and doing aerobic exercises. But before bed, Liang Shi would always add extra training for herself—planks and sit-ups were the two exercises she did most frequently.

She would push herself to the critical point where her body couldn't handle any more, drenched in sweat, exhausted to the point where she couldn't let her mind wander before she would lie in bed and fall asleep.

Her sleep quality used to be very good, but ever since waking up on this side, her sleep quality had taken a sharp downturn.

Even though she kept adding extra training to exhaust herself, she would often wake up startled in the middle of the night.

After waking, she would instinctively reach for the other side of the bed, and only then suddenly realize—she had returned to this world.

In this world, there was no Xu Qingzhu.

Liang Shi would then lie there with her eyes open in a daze, or lie on her side with her head resting on her arm, her back to the window, trying to fall asleep.

But it was very hard to fall asleep.

She would frequently think of Xu Qingzhu.

Frame by frame, like playing a movie, projecting past moments in her mind.

Liang Shi had also cursed that damn system countless times in the night. It must have been because of that bug that day that it sent her back to this world.

Despite her countless curses, the system never appeared.

The hundred days she experienced seemed like a dream.

A beautiful dream she had woven for herself.

A golden millet dream¹—one day the dream would end.

After just a few days, Liang Shi started thinking—that must have been a dream.

But to categorize Xu Qingzhu as someone she met in a dream—deep down, she didn't want to.

That very real feeling from when she first woke up had already disappeared. Days passed one by one, flying by like arrows.

Liang Shi's life seemed like someone had pressed copy-paste—repetitive and boring.

She would watch TV when she woke up in the morning. Xiao Bai would bring her breakfast and urge her to wash up and eat. Though she clearly had no appetite and didn't want to eat at all, Xiao Bai would sit in front of the hospital bed looking at her with teary eyes.

This scene had often appeared in their previous interactions, but back then it was Xiao Bai not wanting to be scolded by Wang-jie, looking at Liang Shi with teary eyes, hoping she wouldn't have late-night snacks.

Even more so hoping Liang Shi wouldn't touch high-calorie foods like milk tea and fast food.

Now it was reversed. Xiao Bai was painting rosy pictures for her every day: "Liang-jie, when you're discharged, I'll take you to eat McDonald's! KFC! Dicos²! You can eat whatever you want—I'll order fried chicken drumsticks for you! Strawberry taro boba! Two burgers!"

Under her supervision, Liang Shi would finish the breakfast she bought, then go downstairs to walk around the hospital grounds with her company.

Oh right, it was already spring here now.

She had been unconscious on this side for exactly one hundred days too.

For her, the flow of time in both worlds was the same.

When she was unconscious, it was still winter here. When she came back, they had passed Christmas Eve, Christmas, New Year's Day, and Chinese New Year.

In the hundred days she was gone, a year had quietly passed here.

The city Liang Shi was in was a first-tier inland city. Driving for two hours would only get you out of the city to its edges—you couldn't see the vast, azure, endless sea.

It rarely rained here. The few rains that fell only came when needed.

For example, during spring plowing, or when the weather needed to warm up.

The proverb "one spring rain brings one warmth, one autumn rain brings one chill" fit this city very well.

The city that had just had several spring rains was warming up. The spring breeze was much gentler than the autumn wind. The air was too dry, so the humidifier in the hospital room was running twenty-four hours a day.

The weeds on the hospital grounds had already started quietly sprouting. Green new buds had emerged on the withered tree trunks.

Everything showed this city's vitality and vigor.

Liang Shi was quieter than before.

She had always been a person of few words, and now even more so.

When Wang Zhaozhao talked to her, she would often find her spacing out.

Liang Shi did rehabilitation at the hospital for a week. After another full body examination showed all her data and indicators were normal, Xiao Bai went to process her discharge paperwork.

While Xiao Bai was handling the procedures, Liang Shi was already sitting on the bed in a daze, the warm spring sun falling on her.

The orange-brown long hair she had dyed for an event hadn't faded noticeably during these three months. It sparkled under the sun, making her appear even more fair-skinned.

She sat facing the window. The towering buildings of this city were like a steel forest, suffocating to behold.

Gray buildings stood in neat rows on the earth, and the top of the tallest building in the farthest distance nearly touched the clouds.

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1. "Golden millet dream" (黃粱大夢) - A famous Chinese idiom originating from a Tang Dynasty story. A young man named Lu fell asleep while waiting for his millet to cook at an inn. He dreamed an entire lifetime of glory—passing imperial exams, becoming an official, marrying well, having children, and eventually dying of old age. When he woke, the millet wasn't even cooked yet. The idiom refers to pipe dreams or the illusory nature of worldly glory and ambitions. ⇐
 2. Dicos (德克士) - A Chinese fast-food chain similar to KFC and McDonald's, known for its fried chicken. It's one of the largest Western-style fast food chains in China. ⇐

Chapter 127-5

Liang Shi heard Xiao Bai and Wang-jie whispering at the doorway.

"Has Liang-jie become depressed? Wuwuwu, the public opinion online has already turned around now."

"I don't know," Wang Zhaozhao said. "I still haven't given her phone back to her."

"Liang-jie is way too quiet, looking all weighed down with worries. Damn it! Who took my gentle Liang-jie and give her back to me!"

"...Stop being so melodramatic."

"No way, tonight I still have to continue battling those hateful keyboard warriors for three hundred rounds."

"...You still haven't given up?"

"How could I possibly give up? I'm going to make it my lifelong career! Standing on the front lines of Liang-jie's anti-hate squad."

"..."

Listening to Xiao Bai's words, Liang Shi suddenly smiled. She lazily turned her head, and her gentle voice rang out in the hospital room: "Xiao Bai."

Xiao Bai immediately responded loudly and hurriedly walked into the room. "Liang-jie, are you hungry?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"It hasn't even been two hours since breakfast," Liang Shi said.

Xiao Bai asked again: "Then are you thirsty?"

Liang Shi shook her head. She stood up with a smile at the corner of her lips.

Her long hair hung loosely on her body. Wearing a taro purple hoodie and light-colored high-waisted casual pants, she stood ramrod straight against the light—gentle and beautiful.

Liang Shi opened her arms, looking at Xiao Bai and Wang Zhaozhao.

Xiao Bai was dumbstruck, her jaw dropping in surprise. After thinking for two seconds, she asked nervously: "Jie, are you still not recovered?"

Liang Shi shook her head, her voice gentle. She smiled and said: "Come, give me a hug."

Xiao Bai was stunned and looked toward Wang Zhaozhao.

Wang Zhaozhao was also completely bewildered.

Xiao Bai walked over hesitantly. When she reached Liang Shi, she stopped, still a bit worried.
"Jie, are you..."

Before she could finish speaking, she was embraced by Liang Shi.

It was just a simple hug.

After hugging her, Liang Shi used her height advantage to pat her head, saying softly:
"Classmate Bai Qi, you've worked hard these days."

With that one sentence, Xiao Bai's eyes instantly welled up with tears.

When she cried for real, she wouldn't go "wuwu" like usual. Her words would choke up, and she couldn't even get out a complete sentence.

Xiao Bai said: "Jie... you... you..."

Liang Shi took the initiative to answer: "I'm fine."

Then Liang Shi looked toward Wang Zhaozhao and extended her arms toward her. "Wang-jie, how about a hug?"

Wang Zhaozhao stood frozen in place for a few seconds, then stepped forward and hugged her, giving her a reproachful pat on the back. "Don't cause any more trouble."

Liang Shi obediently answered: "Okay."

Wang Zhaozhao added: "Don't thank me, thank yourself."

Liang Shi let go of her, smiling gently.

Xiao Bai had already cried herself into a tearful mess.

Wang Zhaozhao said: "It's because you're too good, that's why Xiao Bai and I were both willing to wait for you to come back."

Tears glistened in Liang Shi's eyes. "It's you two who are too good."

Chapter 127-6

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After Liang Shi woke up and saw Xiao Bai, she still hadn't processed everything.

It was only after a few days that she asked Xiao Bai why she hadn't gone to work.

Xiao Bai said she had been waiting for her to come back.

This news surprised Liang Shi, because Xiao Bai had just graduated the year before last and came to work for her right after graduation. Her previous assistants had either left for better opportunities or wanted to switch to a different industry.

So she had hired the freshly graduated, energetic Xiao Bai.

At the time, Xiao Bai had been rejected by dozens of companies. Because her education wasn't impressive, her appearance wasn't outstanding, and her grades in school were mediocre—in this city where you could casually pick up any resume dropped on the ground and it would belong to a graduate from a 985 university¹, Xiao Bai had no advantages whatsoever.

Her becoming Liang Shi's assistant was also an extremely coincidental matter. At the time, Liang Shi had just finished shooting a magazine insert. On her way back, she saw Xiao Bai squatting by the roadside crying her eyes out.

Liang Shi handed her a tissue.

Xiao Bai said: "I recognize you—you're a beautiful jiejie."

Liang Shi's assistant at the time had just submitted her resignation. After learning about Xiao Bai's situation, she let Xiao Bai come try out.

This decision was firmly opposed by Wang Zhaozhao. An artist's assistant would have close contact with the artist's life—if she was a spy sent by a rival, they'd be done for.

But Liang Shi asked back: "Is there anything about me worth digging up?"

That question stumped Wang Zhaozhao completely. Wang Zhaozhao then argued from another angle: "She doesn't know anything—she's a blank slate. How much effort would we have to spend to train her? It's too exhausting."

"Who doesn't go from not knowing to knowing?" Liang Shi said gently. "We'll just teach her slowly."

Though she was clearly only a few years older than Xiao Bai, her manner of speaking was that of an elder.

A very kind elder.

And so Xiao Bai was kept on.

At first, she was indeed quite clumsy, with a careless personality and a loud way of speaking—not a very likeable personality in the workplace.

Wang Zhaozhao wanted to replace her several times.

But Liang Shi just smiled and said to her: "Don't you think she's very energetic? Even after going out to shoot all day and coming home at two in the morning, she's still full of energy. How much joy has she added to our lives?"

Wang Zhaozhao was helpless against her.

Yet unexpectedly, the Xiao Bai she had least confidence in back then had now become the person who stayed by her side all along.

What shocked Liang Shi was that she could no longer pay Xiao Bai's salary here, so what was Xiao Bai's source of income?

Her company had terminated her contract after helping her clean up that mess.

Xiao Bai had previously been paying her own salary out of pocket, but now Xiao Bai hadn't gone out to work for months, spending all her time here with her—how was she supposed to live?

She still had a long road ahead of her.

Yet Xiao Bai smiled and told her: "I do part-time work! During the day when there's a caregiver here for you, I go work as a cashier at a convenience store. At night, I switch shifts with the caregiver."

Liang Shi was shocked beyond words at the time.

She had thought she would be abandoned by this world, that no one would remember she existed.

She was like a gust of wind on the internet—once it blew past, it scattered.

But Xiao Bai, in order to take care of her, had been doing a job that barely counted as work.

She had asked—that part-time job paid two thousand yuan a month. In this city where every inch of land was precious, that could only rent a single room.

Xiao Bai said: "I saved a lot of the salary you paid me before. I'm someone with savings now."

Moreover, Xiao Bai was now living at Wang-jie's place.

Even so, it was enough to move Liang Shi deeply.

Wang-jie had not taken on any new artists after her. Her contract with the company happened to expire, so she left the company directly. Now she didn't have much to do either.

When Liang Shi asked her about it, she said she had earned enough money and was retiring early.

The two of them always maintained an attitude of nonchalance, but Liang Shi could hear the warmth between the lines.

After she woke up, her body was clean, she was staying in a quality private room, and even her hair was soft and smooth.

So during the time she was unconscious, the people who had put aside everything to take care of her were these two.

Liang Shi really wanted to give them a hug and tell them: Don't worry anymore.

On the day of her discharge, the three of them went to eat hotpot.

When ordering, Liang Shi briefly thought of Xu Qingzhu, and so she ordered a devil's spicy soup base.

This action startled both Xiao Bai and Wang-jie.

Wang-jie was always strict and scolded her: "You don't want your stomach or your face anymore?"

Liang Shi shrugged: "It's not like I need to film anyway."

She wasn't someone who could handle spicy food well, and this body's constitution was such that eating spicy food would definitely cause breakouts.

To withstand the camera lighting, she usually ate bland and plain food.

Wang-jie gave a light huff and tacitly accepted her behavior.

The old her couldn't handle even a bit of spice, but now—perhaps because she had eaten devil's spicy food with Xu Qingzhu several times—she could now handle this restaurant's devil's spicy level.

When she ate it, she didn't even furrow her brows.

Xiao Bai and Wang-jie watched with their jaws dropped.

When they went back that night, Wang-jie bought her stomach medicine.

Liang Shi sat in the back seat and chuckled softly. "It's really not that exaggerated."

"Just in case," Wang-jie said seriously.

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1. 985 university - Refers to universities in China's "Project 985," an elite group of 39 top-tier universities that receive special government funding. Graduating from a 985 university is considered highly prestigious and gives graduates significant advantages in the job market. ↩

Chapter 127-7

A week after waking up, Liang Shi returned home. This place was also spotlessly clean.

Moreover, as soon as she pushed open the door, she saw colorful balloons bumping against the ceiling, with words written on them in colored markers: Welcome Home.

Xiao Bai stood to the side acting as the atmosphere crew. A party popper went off, and confetti ribbons fell onto Liang Shi.

Through the huge floor-to-ceiling windows, Liang Shi could see this city's night view—lights sparkling brilliantly. Yet the light in her home was the most inconspicuous one in this entire city.

Xiao Bai shouted loudly: "Welcome home, Liang-jie!"

Liang Shi smiled helplessly: "You're cleaning this up later."

Xiao Bai's face immediately fell, and she said pitifully: "Can I clean it up tomorrow?"

Liang Shi said righteously: "No."

After returning home, Liang Shi's footsteps measured every floor tile. She and Wang Zhaozhao nestled on the sofa. After Xiao Bai finished sweeping up the confetti ribbons on the floor, she opened a bottle of wine.

Xiao Bai's eyes lit up after taking a sip. "Jie, this wine is really expensive, isn't it?!"

Liang Shi nodded.

Wang Zhaozhao was beside them, looking like a wealthy person showing off: "It's alright, just over two hundred thousand."

Xiao Bai: "..."

Liang Shi nestled in the corner of the sofa watching Bai Qi carefully take sip after sip, finally frowning and saying: "I don't taste any difference between this and wine that costs a few hundred."

Wang Zhaozhao: "Your palate isn't refined enough."

Xiao Bai looked dejected and let out a soft scoff, not quite daring to.

"Getting bold, are we?" Wang Zhaozhao threatened her.

Xiao Bai immediately backed down. "I was wrong."

During the days she had been unconscious in the hospital, the two of them had built up a unique rapport.

Wang Zhaozhao had finally come to appreciate Xiao Bai's good qualities, and Xiao Bai no longer rigidly thought of Wang Zhaozhao as "Wang the Slave Driver."¹

Watching them bicker, Liang Shi also felt very warm.

One expensive bottle of wine was finished by the three of them, and Liang Shi was already slightly tipsy.

This wine had quite an aftereffect.

After seeing that she was fine, Wang Zhaozhao and Xiao Bai left her home. Although Xiao Bai had worriedly asked if she wanted company tonight.

But Liang Shi declined.

After they left, Liang Shi took her newly returned phone and opened her social media apps.

Almost all of her social apps showed 99+.

Because she valued her privacy, Wang Zhaozhao hadn't touched her phone after she fell into a coma.

She now read through the messages one by one. Many artist friends had sent her messages of concern.

There was even one artist who came out: "Actually, I also like girls."

It was the third female lead she had worked with while filming before. She wasn't particularly outstanding in appearance, but had a gentle temperament and spoke softly—the kind of little sister that made people want to protect her.

Liang Shi finished reading through the messages one by one, then posted on her Moments²:
【Spring should be wonderful, if only you were still here.】

This was a song lyric.

A song Liang Shi had been listening to constantly these days.

She turned on the record player at home. The antique item with its unique sense of a bygone era pulled her into that old period of time, but her thoughts kept drifting.

A gentle voice sang in Cantonese, carrying a special charm.

Outside, the lights were bright, stars dotted the sky, and the moon hung high above.

This was the most ordinary spring.

Yet it was a spring without Xu Qingzhu.

The golden millet dream had ended.

Yesterday's scene would never return.

Liang Shi curled up alone in the corner of the sofa, unable to sleep through the long, endless night.

1. "Wang the Slave Driver" (王扒皮) - A nickname playing on Wang Zhaozhao's surname. "扒皮" literally means "skin-peeler" and is a reference to a notorious landlord character from Chinese revolutionary literature known for exploiting workers. It's used colloquially to describe someone who is very demanding or harsh, like a slave driver. ⇐
2. Moments (朋友圈) - WeChat's social media feature similar to Facebook's timeline/feed, where users can post updates, photos, and thoughts that their friends can see and interact with. ⇐

Chapter 127-8

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Xu Qingzhu's life returned to its normal track.

She took the initiative to talk with Dr. Gu about her condition, about the scene that day. She said she was afraid of that kind of place, afraid of the feeling of having her eyes covered, and even more afraid of the person who desperately protected her disappearing.

She said so much.

Dr. Gu became a very good listener.

Xu Qingzhu's ability to self-regulate was so much better than when she was a child. After telling all of this, she took the initiative to say to Dr. Gu: "Please prescribe me some medication that can suppress these emotions. I will try my best to overcome it psychologically."

She said she needed to get better, because if Liang Shi saw her like this when she woke up, she would be very sad.

That gentle person always liked to take all the problems upon herself.

So Xu Qingzhu needed to protect herself well. She couldn't have worked so hard to live all these years only to still be that same little girl from back then.

When Xu Qingzhu had just woken up before, it was like she was standing on the edge of a cliff.

Below the cliff was vast fog, bottomlessly deep.

She kept swaying there, constantly wavering, as if she could fall at any moment.

No one appeared to pull her back.

At the time, she was already trying hard to control her emotions, but it was still futile.

But when she heard Liang Shi's name, the thick fog at the bottom of the cliff seemed to disperse all at once.

She saw the abyss, saw those pitch-black things.

Xu Qingzhu thought at the time—what would happen if she fell?

Would it be release?

Her consciousness was scattering, but the moment she saw Liang Shi, she thought: falling wasn't release.

Living well was.

Someone appeared at the edge of the cliff and pulled her back.

Xu Qingzhu knew she still had things left unfinished, still had someone to protect.

In this world, there were far too many people who needed her.

Behind Liang Shi stood row after row of people, all looking at her earnestly, hoping she would get better.

Even if only for them, she had to get better.

Xu Qingzhu worked hard to overcome her emotions. One great advantage of becoming an adult was that emotions were much more stable than in childhood. Even if she recalled painful memories in that moment and scene, after leaving the environment, she would quickly digest those emotions.

Because she had built up tolerance.

Adults already understood: living itself was a difficult thing.

After Xu Qingzhu finished her examination and had no problems, she was discharged.

On the day of her discharge, she sat in Liang Shi's hospital room for half the afternoon. With nothing to do, she drew.

She also had great talent for drawing. With just a few casual strokes, she could outline Liang Shi's features. The Liang Shi she drew had the corners of her mouth turned upward.

Even though she was now sleeping, the her in memory was the gentlest.

That evening, she went to the Su family's home for dinner. Sheng Linlang and Xu Guangyao also went.

Xu Qingya and Su Meiqi were chatting very well together. Sheng Yu kept trying to insert herself into their conversation, only to be rejected by Xu Qingya: "You're stealing my jiejie. I won't play with you."

Sheng Yu widened her eyes and retorted: "You're clearly the one stealing my jiejie!"

Xu Qingya was just teasing her and wasn't serious, but the little kid took it seriously.

Being so young, she was definitely no match for Xu Qingya, so she ran to tattle to Xu Qingzhu, nestling in Xu Qingzhu's arms and refusing to get up no matter what.

That night, Sheng Yu even made a fuss about wanting to sleep with Xu Qingzhu.

And she did it first and asked for permission later—after her bath, she ran directly to the room prepared for Xu Qingzhu, hugged a little bear plushie, and burrowed under the covers. When Su Yao tried to carry her out, she refused to leave no matter what.

In the end, Xu Qingzhu said: "Just let her stay. She can keep me company."

Su Yao was helpless. "She has bad sleeping habits. She kicks people."

Having been exposed, Sheng Yu said boldly despite being in the wrong: "I've changed now! If you don't believe me, sleep with me for one night and you'll see!"

Xu Qingzhu was amused by her.

Right before sleep that night, Sheng Yu asked Xu Qingzhu in a low voice: "Jiejie, were you scared when the bad guys caught you?"

Xu Qingzhu's thoughts were drifting. She thought of Liang Shi.

There clearly weren't many nights spent together with Liang Shi, but when she thought of her, the memories were exceptionally vivid.

It seemed like only when she existed was there light; all other times were dim.

Hearing this, Xu Qingzhu was momentarily dazed. Her hand fell on Sheng Yu's hair as she said softly: "A little scared."

She was comforting the child.

But the child nestled in her arms and said very boldly: "Jiejie, don't be scared! I'll protect you from now on!"

"Okay." Xu Qingzhu smiled.

Little Demon King Sheng said: "I'll punch the bad guys' heads, kick the bad guys' legs, beat them until they're howling, so they won't dare bully you and Liang-jiejie."

Xu Qingzhu didn't know how a five-year-old child had so many strange things to say. She could only respond: "Okay."

After a moment, Sheng Yu asked in a muffled voice: "Jiejie, do you really miss Liang-jiejie?"

Xu Qingzhu was stunned. She closed her eyes, and a tear fell. That cool, clear voice was full of tenderness and longing: "Yes."

—I miss her so, so much.

Xu Qingzhu was afraid she had gone to her world and would never come back.

What she feared even more was that she hadn't even made it to her world.

Rather than having Liang Shi stay by her side, she hoped more that Liang Shi was alive.

Even if she never saw Liang Shi again in her lifetime.

As long as she knew Liang Shi was safe and well, that would be enough.

Sheng Yu patted her back with a little adult's tone: "Liang-jiejie will wake up."

Sheng Yu said: "The princess is just dreaming. Her dream must be wonderful."

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Perhaps."

"One day you'll kiss your princess awake." Sheng Yu's voice was already drowsy, but she still said: "Once the princess wakes up, she'll love you forever and ever."

Xu Qingzhu was comforted by her dreamy tone. Stroking her hair with deep affection, she said: "Yes, the princess will always love me."

—Even if I don't kiss her awake.

—Even if the princess doesn't love me, I will always love my princess.

—Because in this crowded world, there is no one like her.

Chapter 127-9

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Spring in this city was very warm.

There was no rain, and the temperature remained stable.

Liang Shi had been back here for nearly half a month—the first week in the hospital, the second week at home.

She would occasionally go out to buy groceries. At the supermarket, she would be recognized by the aunties. They wouldn't call her that scandal-ridden celebrity Liang Shi, but would call out her character's name and say with great surprise: "I've watched the TV drama you acted in."

They would also praise her: "You're even prettier in person than on TV."

Liang Shi would just smile gently.

The nationwide hostility she had imagined never came. Everyone she met in reality was very gentle.

Some would even refuse to take her money when she went to buy fruit at a small stall because she was a celebrity.

She would still secretly pay anyway.

During this week, she had tried to find Sun Chengcheng, but Sun Chengcheng had moved. She didn't have Sun Chengcheng's contact information.

She had once placed all her hopes of returning on Sun Chengcheng.

But now, Sun Chengcheng had disappeared to the point where even Wang-jie couldn't find her.

Liang Shi could only be forced to become zen about it.

It's just that as time went on, everything she had experienced there became blurry, as if it really had been just a dream—a dream where she met a wonderful girl.

They commuted to work together, ate breakfast together, ate dinner together, embraced, kissed, slept together.

Moved from a villa to a small house.

From living in two rooms to one room.

Her life was calm and uneventful, her mindset much more peaceful than before.

Because she had no plans to return to the entertainment industry, she was also prepared to leave here at any time. She gave the money she had been saving to Xiao Bai and had her open a bakery.

Under the pretense of being a shareholder.

Wang Zhaozhao directly registered an agency company and asked if she wanted to move from being in front of the camera to behind the scenes. But she had no career ambitions and just teased: "I just recovered and you're already exploiting my remaining labor value? Wang the Slave Driver really lives up to her name."

Wang Zhaozhao rolled her eyes at her. "So dramatic."

But Liang Shi quite enjoyed this ordinary city life.

Her Moments post that day had sparked a heated discussion. There were nearly a hundred comments below, all asking if she had woken up.

Some also asked if she was going to return to the industry.

She only replied to a few people she had decent relationships with.

Every day here was the same—waking up early, sleeping late, insomnia, missing Xu Qingzhu.

Over and over again.

She was even afraid that she would forget this person, that one day she would truly think it was all just a dream she had experienced.

So every day she would write Xu Qingzhu's name many times in a notebook.

She wanted to make herself remember.

The spring rain of this city quietly arrived one night, pattering down throughout the night.

The next morning when Liang Shi went to buy groceries, she took a different route. Because she had woken up too early, she wanted to visit the morning market and buy a fresh fish to make fish soup.

The air after the rain carried the fresh scent of earth. The asphalt road had changed from light to dark, and the humidity in the air was too high.

By morning the rain had stopped, but the temperature had dropped somewhat.

Liang Shi had worn a long coat when she came out. Few shops on this road were open, but there was one flower shop that was already open.

The flower shop seemed to be newly opened, with a banner still hanging that read "Grand Opening Special." The delicate flowers could lift one's spirits even through the glass. Liang Shi stood there thinking for two seconds about whether to go in and buy a bouquet.

Just as she reached a decision, the flower shop door was pushed open. The shop owner came out carrying an enormous potted plant. The other person was not very strong, wobbling as she walked while carrying it. Liang Shi immediately stepped forward to help.

The potted plant was placed steadily on the ground. The other person raised her hand to wipe the sweat from her forehead and smiled gently: "Thank you."

Liang Shi's gaze fixed on her face. She called out in astonishment: "Qi Jiao?"

The girl was surprised. "How do you know my name?"